

SOLUTIONS ENGINEER PREPARATION PLAN

SE Prep Roadmap 2026

Ruvarashe Madzime | May to July 2026 | Target: Remote USD or EUR role

THE PLAN AT A GLANCE

This is your 3-month preparation window before full job applications begin in August 2026. You are finishing your MSc at the same time. Weeks marked **[MSc week]** should be lighter on career prep to protect your thesis.

PRIMARY TARGET

Solutions Engineer

AI/ML SaaS company

BACKUP TARGET

AI Governance

Big 4 or specialist firm

INCOME GOAL

\$65K-\$90K

USD yr 1. Clears visa.

You are a published 24-year-old XAI specialist in the hottest compliance topic in enterprise AI. The credentials are real. The market is real. This is the roadmap.

01
MONTH

MAY 2026

Foundation and Positioning

Week 1 to 2 (May 1-14)

IDENTITY RESET

Everything downstream depends on reframing how you present yourself. You are no longer an academic. You are an Explainable AI specialist with a formal publication, moving into industry.

WEEK 1 TO 2

Positioning and Profiles

- ☐ Rewrite LinkedIn headline: "Explainable AI Specialist | MSc CS | Published Researcher NMR 2026"
- ☐ Rewrite LinkedIn About section: commercial framing, under 300 words, no academic tone
- ☐ Rebuild CV as a 1-page international SE resume focused on achievements not descriptions
- ☐ Add NMR 2026 paper to LinkedIn Publications with a plain-English description
- ☐ Email Tommie: request warm introductions to industry contacts and a reference letter
- ☐ Create profiles on Wellfound and We Work Remotely *[MSc week]*

RESOURCES FOR WEEK 1 TO 2

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
LinkedIn profile guide	LinkedIn Help: Optimise your profile	Free, official guide
SE resume examples	Resumeworded SE templates	Free examples
CV power verbs list	The Muse: 185 resume action verbs	Free article
Wellfound profile setup	Wellfound (formerly AngelList)	Free, best startup job board

Week 3 to 4 (May 15-31)

SAAS LITERACY AND MARKET MAPPING

You need to speak the language of the business world before your first interview. SaaS metrics, sales frameworks, and the EU AI Act are the vocabulary of your target roles.

WEEK 3 TO 4

Business Context and Setup

- ☐ Learn SaaS metrics: ARR, MRR, Churn, NPS, CAC, LTV and what each means commercially *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Learn MEDDIC sales framework - the methodology SEs operate inside *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Read EU AI Act Articles 9, 13, 14 - understand explainability requirements legally *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Research and build your list of 30 target companies across SE and governance tracks
- ☐ Open a Wise account - get your USD, GBP and EUR account details (15 minutes, free)
- ☐ Open Interactive Brokers account - takes 1-2 weeks to verify, start now
- ☐ Send your first 10 personalised LinkedIn connection requests to SEs at target companies

RESOURCES FOR WEEK 3 TO 4

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
SaaS metrics explained	Baremetrics SaaS Glossary	Free, best single resource
MEDDIC framework	MEDDIC Academy overview	Free overview
HubSpot SaaS sales blog	HubSpot Sales Blog	Free articles
EU AI Act full text	Official EU AI Act Articles	Free, read Arts 9, 13, 14
EU AI Act plain English	Future of Life Institute summary	Free plain-language summary
XAI company landscape	AI Multiple: XAI tools overview	Free market map
Wise account	Wise international money account	Free to open, USD/EUR/GBP
Interactive Brokers	IBKR global brokerage	Low fees, accepts SA residents

02
MONTH

J U N E 2 0 2 6

Technical Skills

Week 1 to 2 (June 1-14)

SQL FLUENCY

SQL is the most tested technical skill in SE interviews. You use it during live demos to pull data from a prospect's database and show results in real time. It is NOT heavy coding. It reads like English.

"Show me all customers who churned in Q1 with monthly spend above \$5,000." That is a SQL query. That is the level you need.

WEEK 1 TO 2

SQL for Live Demos

- ☐ Complete Mode Analytics free SQL tutorial: SELECT, WHERE, GROUP BY, JOIN, subqueries *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Complete 20 SQL practice exercises on SQLZoo starting at easy level
- ☐ Write a query answering a real business question: e.g. which model version has highest accuracy per customer segment
- ☐ Send 10 more LinkedIn connection requests, aiming to book 2 informational interviews this month

RESOURCES FOR SQL

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Mode SQL Tutorial	Mode Analytics SQL School	Free, best structured course
SQLZoo practice	SQLZoo interactive exercises	Free, hands-on practice
W3Schools SQL	W3Schools SQL reference	Free, quick reference
LeetCode SQL Easy	LeetCode Database problems	Free, real interview questions
Khan Academy SQL	Khan Academy SQL intro course	Free, beginner friendly

Week 3 to 4 (June 15-30)

AWS CLOUD PRACTITIONER CERTIFICATION AND API LITERACY

The AWS Cloud Practitioner certification (\$100 exam) is a keyword filter. It gets your CV past automated screeners at over 70% of AI/ML SaaS companies. It teaches you vocabulary and concepts, not deep engineering. Budget around 30 hours total study time.

WEEK 3 TO 4

Cloud Cert and API Basics

- ☐ Study for AWS Cloud Practitioner using one of the free resources below (around 30 hours total) *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Book and sit the AWS Cloud Practitioner exam (\$100, book at aws.training)
- ☐ Learn API basics: what an API is, how to read API docs, make real calls using Postman
- ☐ Try the free tiers of Fiddler AI, Arize AI, and Evidently AI - click around, understand what they do
- ☐ Attend at least 1 informational interview from your LinkedIn outreach this month

RESOURCES FOR AWS CLOUD PRACTITIONER

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
AWS Skill Builder (official)	AWS Cloud Practitioner Essentials - free	Free, official AWS content
Stephane Maarek on Udemy	AWS CLF-C02 Udemy course	Around \$15 on sale, most popular
Andrew Brown on YouTube	Free 14-hour AWS CLF course	Free, very comprehensive
ExamPro practice tests	AWS CLF practice questions	Free tier available
Exam booking page	AWS Certification CLF-C02	\$100 exam, book when ready

RESOURCES FOR API LITERACY

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Postman Learning Center	Postman API fundamentals	Free, install Postman first
What is an API	MuleSoft plain English explainer	Free, 5-minute read
REST API Tutorial	REST API Tutorial site	Free, practical intro
Fiddler AI free trial	Fiddler AI XAI platform	Free trial, XAI focus
Arize AI free tier	Arize ML observability platform	Free tier, try the UI
Evidently AI	Evidently open source ML tool	Free open source, easiest to start

03
MONTH

J U L Y 2 0 2 6

Portfolio and Interview Prep

Week 1 to 2 (July 1-14)

BUILD AND DEPLOY THE PORTFOLIO PROJECT

This is the most important deliverable of your entire 3 months. One public project that answers "show me something you built" in every interview. Use your ECCRS research as the foundation.

The project: upload a CSV, train a model, generate ECCRS rules, show plain-English explanations and SHAP visualisations. Deploy publicly. Anyone can use it from a browser.

WEEK 1 TO 2

ECCRS Explainer App

- ☐ Build the ECCRS Streamlit app: CSV upload, decision tree training, rule extraction, plain-English explanations
- ☐ Add SHAP visualisation showing which features drove each prediction *[MSc week]*
- ☐ Deploy publicly on Streamlit Community Cloud (free hosting)
- ☐ Push clean, documented code to a public GitHub repository with a strong README

RESOURCES FOR THE PORTFOLIO PROJECT

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Streamlit documentation	Streamlit official docs	Free, start here
Streamlit Community Cloud	Free Streamlit app hosting	Free hosting
SHAP library documentation	SHAP explainability library	Free, pip install shap
Scikit-learn decision trees	Sklearn tree documentation	Free, you already know this
GitHub new repo guide	GitHub quickstart guide	Free
How to write a good README	Make a README guide	Free, 10-minute read

Week 3 to 4 (July 15-31)

INTERVIEW PREP AND FIRST APPLICATIONS

Be interview-ready before you submit a single application. Companies that see a strong first application from you remember it. Practice your pitch, your demo, and your story before you go live.

WEEK 3 TO 4

Pitch, Practice, Apply

- ☐ Record a 5-minute demo video of yourself walking through the portfolio app. Watch it back. Redo it.
- ☐ Prepare and practise your "why industry" narrative out loud: 90 seconds, ten times *[IMSc week]*
- ☐ Prepare personal pitch: who you are, what you built, what problem you solve, under 2 minutes
- ☐ Do 3 mock SE customer roleplay sessions with a friend or practice partner
- ☐ Prepare STAR answers for 5 common behavioural interview questions
- ☐ Research each of your 30 target companies: product, customers, competitors, recent news
- ☐ Build your application tracker spreadsheet: company, role, date applied, status, contact
- ☐ Submit 5 applications in the last week of July as a warm-up round

RESOURCES FOR INTERVIEW PREP

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
SE interview guide	Winning SE Interviews guide	Free, best SE-specific resource
STAR method explained	Indeed STAR method guide	Free
Free mock interviews	Pramp peer mock interviews	Free, practice with real people
SE community hub	PreSales Collective	Free to join
Company intel	Glassdoor interview questions	Free, see real SE interview Qs
How customers talk about products	G2 software reviews	Free, understand customer language

WHERE TO FIND REMOTE USD/EUR JOBS

Only apply where listings say "global," "worldwide," "Deel," "Remote.com," or list salary in USD or EUR. Ignore listings that say "US only" or "must be authorised to work in EU." Those are not for you.

Niche Job Boards

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Wellfound (AngelList)	wellfound.com/jobs - filter: Solutions Engineer + Remote	Free, best startup board
We Work Remotely	Curated genuinely global remote roles	Free to browse
Remote OK	Filter by role and your GMT+2 timezone	Free, check timezone filter
EU Remote Jobs	European companies paying in EUR	Free, your timezone is perfect for EU
Y Combinator jobs	YC portfolio companies, high growth	Free, many remote-first
Dynamite Jobs	Verified global remote roles, Africa-friendly	Free
Otta	UK and EU tech companies	Free, good UK/EU SE listings
Climate Base	Climate tech AI, EUR/USD European companies	Free
LinkedIn Remote filter	LinkedIn SE jobs - filter worldwide + remote	Free

How to Spot a Genuinely Global Company

GREEN FLAGS	RED FLAGS
"We hire globally" or "location independent"	"Must be authorised to work in the US/EU"
"Via Deel, Remote.com, or Multiplier"	"EST/PST hours required" with no flexibility
"EMEA welcome" or "Africa welcome"	No mention of international payroll infrastructure
Salary listed in USD or EUR explicitly	Salary listed as "competitive" with no currency

Target Companies - Start Here

These companies are known to hire globally via Deel or Remote.com and pay in USD or EUR. Prioritise these over unknown companies.

Company	What they do	Why you fit
Fiddler AI	XAI and model monitoring platform	<i>Your ECCRS research is literally what they sell</i>
Arize AI	ML observability and explainability	<i>Direct XAI overlap, highest profile fit</i>
Arthur AI	Enterprise AI monitoring	<i>Governance and fairness focus</i>
Evidently AI	Open source ML monitoring	<i>European company, your GMT+2 timezone</i>
Weights and Biases	ML experiment tracking platform	<i>Widely used, strong global hiring track record</i>
Hugging Face	AI model hub and platform	<i>Team across 30+ countries, fully distributed</i>
Databricks	Data and AI lakehouse platform	<i>Large SE function, established global hiring</i>
DataRobot	Enterprise AutoML platform	<i>Strong SE team, hires internationally</i>
Cohere	Enterprise LLM APIs	<i>Canadian company, explicitly global remote</i>
Scale AI	Data labelling and AI platform	<i>Large global contractor and employee network</i>
Deloitte AI practice	AI governance consulting	<i>Governance backup, SA office exists</i>
KPMG AI advisory	Responsible AI consulting	<i>EU AI Act demand, SA office for local hiring</i>

VISA QUICK REFERENCE

Digital Nomad Visa vs Critical Skills Visa

Feature	Digital Nomad Visa (PRIMARY)	Critical Skills Visa (BACKUP ONLY)
Duration	Up to 3 years, renewable annually	Up to 5 years, renewable
Employer	Must work for a FOREIGN company only	Must have a South African employer
Income threshold	R650,976/year (around \$37K USD)	No floor but must meet SA labour law
Arbitrage-compatible?	YES - built for USD/EUR earners in SA	NO - you earn ZAR, killing arbitrage
Path to PR?	No direct pathway to permanent residency	Yes, after 5 years proven experience
SAQA evaluation?	Not required	Required, start early as it takes months
Professional body?	Not required	Must register with IITPSA after graduation
Verdict for Ruva	Apply 3 months after job starts	Last resort only if Digital Nomad fails

Your Digital Nomad Visa Timeline

Aug to Sep 2026	Apply aggressively for SE and governance roles
Oct to Nov 2026	Receive offer, sign your foreign employment contract
Nov to Dec 2026	Start work, begin earning in USD or EUR
Jan to Feb 2027	Accumulate 3 months of payslips as income proof
Feb 2027	Submit Digital Nomad Visa application (4-8 weeks processing)
Mar to Apr 2027	Visa approved, legal status confirmed
May 2027	ZEP expires. You are already on Digital Nomad Visa. Solved.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

XAI and ML Industry Context

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Interpretable ML book	Christoph Molnar - free online textbook	Free, authoritative XAI reference
SHAP explained visually	SHAP explained on Towards Data Science	Free article
Evidently AI blog	ML monitoring concepts in plain English	Free, very practical
Arize AI blog	ML observability concepts	Free, understand the market
Chip Huyen ML Systems	Designing Machine Learning Systems (book)	Buy or borrow, essential reading

Solutions Engineering Career

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Sales Engineer community	SalesEngineer.io hub	Free, read everything here
PreSales Collective	Global SE community and resources	Free to join
SE Masterclass YouTube	PreSales Collective YouTube channel	Free YouTube content
Jacco van der Kooij	SaaS sales fundamentals on YouTube	Free, excellent business context

Remote Work and Financial Setup

Resource	Where to go	Cost + notes
Digital Nomad Visa SA guide	Citizen Remote: full 2026 guide	Free, updated 2026
Deel contractor guide SA	How companies hire you in SA	Free, understand the process
Xpatweb immigration	SA immigration specialists for ZEP holders	Paid consult, worth it for ZEP transition
Wise international account	Wise: receive USD, EUR, GBP	Free to open, essential for arbitrage

Interactive Brokers SA	IBKR global brokerage for SA residents	Low fees, buy VOO/VTI ETFs
VOO ETF (S&P 500)	Vanguard S&P 500 ETF info	Free info, your main investment vehicle

T H E B O T T O M L I N E

You have a published paper, a formal MSc, and XAI expertise at the exact moment the world needs it most. Three months of focused preparation is not a long time. It is enough time. Start with Week 1.

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